

Independent War Or History of Bangladesh Article 01

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1 Preparation for the Liberation War

The Awami League achieved an absolute majority in the national and provincial elections held in 1970. The Junta of Pakistan started hatching the plot to not to hand over the power to the Awami League. Yahia Khan called for the session of the national assembly on 3 March 1971. Pakistan People's Party chief Zulfikar Ali Bhutto refused to join the session in Dhaka and threatened other members to refrain them from joining. It was the part of a Bhutto-Yahia conspiracy. Yahia Khan postponed the session of 3 March sine die through a statement on 1 March using the refusal of Bhutto as a pretext. The people of East Bengal exploded into agitation against the decision of suspending the session without discussing with Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the leader of the party got the absolute majority in the election. Strikes were observed on the call of All Party Action Committee and Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman on 2 March in Dhaka and 3 March throughout the country in protest against postponing the session. As a result, all the activities of the government came to a standstill. During hartal, police and army opened fire leaving hundred killed and injured. Bangabandhu called for a non-cooperation movement, and under this circumstances, he delivered his historic speech on 7 March in a huge gathering at the Racecourse (now Suhrawardi Uddan). Addressing the people, he urged all Bengalees to participate in armed struggle for liberation. After a bloody war of nine months, Bangladesh emerged on the world map as an independent country.

2 The importance of the oration of 7th March in achieving the liberation of Bangladesh

Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman delivered a historic oration on 7 March at the Racecourse (present Suhrawardi Uddyan). In his speech, he, pointing to the glorious background of the political history of the Bengalees, gave a detail account of the oppression, misrule and the awful deprivation of the Bengalees by the West Pakistan government, particularly the oration is a historic document particularly for the Bengalees and for the world. In recognition to its value, on 30 October 2017, UNESCO added the speech in the Memory of the World Register as documentary heritage. Of the speeches notable in the history of the world, the speech of 7 March is remarkable, and it will be immortal to the people's aspiring freedom and independence, The Bengalees got the

inspiration for being united and the indication for joining the liberation war from the speech of 7 March. Only one target was fixed before them from then onwards, and it was nothing but the freedom. The Bangalees started getting preparation for the liberation war after the formal call for the independence by Bangabandhu in his speech of 7 March. Giving suggestions and further he urged the people, 'build forts in every house, and face the foes with whatever you have.' 'As we've sacrificed our lives, we will sacrifice again, we will liberate the people of this country, Inshallah.' 'This Struggle is the struggle for our freedom, and this struggle is the struggle for our liberation', he added. In this speech, he also highlighted the strategy of war, ways to face enemies, resisting technique, etc. Bangabandhu clearly declared the independence of Bangladesh in his historic 7 March speech. The Bangalees joined the liberation war responding to the call for independence by Bangabandhu. The Pakistan army swooped on the innocent Bangalees in the night of 25 March and started genocide. The Bengalees were raising stiff resistance against the invading Pakistani forces.

3 The Formal Journey to Independence

People from all walks of life were united responding to the call for independence and the activities declared by Bangabandhu on 7 March 1971. All the offices, educational institutions, judiciary department, factories and industries remained closed since then. As the situation of East Pakistan rapidly deteriorating, Yahia Khan came to Dhaka to talk to Bangabandhu. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman Bhutto also came to Dhaka then. They were pretending as well as wasting time in the name of holding talks and meeting, but they secretly assembled soldiers, arms and ammunition to East Bengal from West Pakistan as a part of the preparation of war. Tikka Khan and Rao Farman Ali designed a blue print named the 'Operation Search Light' on 17 March to make the Bangalees victims of mass killings. The brutal mass killing in the history of world civilisation began in the night of 25 March. Yahia and Bhutto secretly left Dhaka. The Pakistani Army launched attack on the innocent people by the order of Yahia Khan, and indiscriminately killed people. They attacked the Police line of Razarbagh, the EPR camp of Pilkhana, the University of Dhaka and the other important establishments of Dhaka city and committed genocide. It is called Kalratri (blackout) in the history of Bangladesh. This night is recognized as National Genocide Day. Bangabandhu declared the independence in the hours of blackout on 25 March, i.e. at the early hour of 26

March, and transmitted the message through wireless to different places. Hearing the declaration of the independence by Bangabandhu, the people instantly initiated resistance in Chittagong and other districts of the country. So an uneven war broke out between the Pakistan armed forces and the unarmed Ansar, police, and common people of East Pakistan. It is known as the great Liberation war of Bangladesh. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was arrested at the midnight, nearly at 1.30 am of 26 March, and was secretly taken away to West Pakistan.

4 The declaration of Independence

Bangabandhu declared the independence of Bangladesh at the midnight of 25 March Le. in the early hour of 26 March just before his arrest by the Pakistani Army. The declaration was in English so that the people around the world could understand it. The declaration was as follows: 'This may be my last message, from today Bangladesh is independent. I call upon the people of Bangladesh wherever you might be and with whatever you have, to resist the army of occupation to the last. Your fight must go on until the last soldier of the Pakistan occupation army is expelled from the soil of Bangladesh and final victory is achieved.'**(Bangladesh Gazette, Fifteenth Amendment of the Constitution, 3 July 2011)**. The declaration of independence was broadcast all over the Bangladesh through the radio transmitter of EPR, telegram and tele-printer. M.A Hannan, a leader of the Chattogram Awami League broadcast the declaration of independence by Bangabandhu at noon through Chattogram Radio Station and subsequently through Kalurghat radio station in the evening on 26 March. Major Ziaur Rahman again proclaimed the declaration on behalf of Bangabandhu in the evening of 27 March through the same radio station. The freedom aspiring people became very much enthusiastic hearing the declaration of independence by Bangabandhu and the immediate support and participation of Bangalee officers in the army, para military and other forces.

5 The commencement of the War of Liberation and the Activities of the Mujibnagar Government

Before the Operation Search Light Began on 25th March, 1971, Bangabandhu discussed with his close associates the situation that then prevailed. He gave them directives to resist if the Pakistani army would attack. He imparted important instructions to the elected representatives about the formation of Government and other matters during the liberation war. The formation of the Mujibnagar Government was very important in the history of liberation. The mango grove of Baidyanathpala of Meherpur was named Mujibnagar after the name of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. The Mujibnagar government was formed on 10 April 1971 with the elected members of the national and provincial assembly in the 1970s general election to run the war by giving necessary directives as well as to drum up the support of the foreign countries. This was the first Bangladesh Government. The order of the declaration of independence of Bangladesh' i. e. the declaration of independence was formally proclaimed on that day. The Mujibnagar government took oath on 17 April 1971, and the government of independent Bangladesh came into being with taking this oath.

The structure of the Mujibnagar Independent Government was as follows:

1. President and Commander in Chief of the Liberation War: Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.
2. Vice President: Syed Nazrul Islam.
3. Prime Minister: Tajuddin Ahmed..
4. Finance Minister: M. Mansur Ali.
5. Home, Relief and Rehabilitation Minister: A.H.M Kamaruzzaman.
6. Foreign and Law Minister: Khondoker Mostaq Ahmed.

An advisory committee of 6 members was formed to provide necessary suggestions and guidance to government of Independent of Bangladesh.

The Mujibnagar government was formed with the elected members of the national and provincial assembly in the general election of 1970. The government ran the administration by the Bangalee officials, There were 12 ministries or divisions in it. Those were the Ministry of Foreign affairs; the Ministry of Finance, Industry and Commerce; the Cabinet Secretariat; the General

Administration; the Health and Welfare Division: the Relief and Rehabilitation Division ,the Engineering Division, the Planning Commission: the Controlling Board for Youth and Reception Camp etc. The Mujibnagar Government established Bangladesh mission in various important cities (Calcutta, Delhi, London, Washington, New York, Stockholm) of the world. These missions campaigned for having support in favour of Bangladesh from the world community. The government appointed Justice Abu Sayed Chowdhary as a special envoy. He tried his best to get support of world leaders and the public as well in favour of the Liberation War. After the formation of the Mujibnagar government on 10 April. a force of the freedom fighters with the Bangalee soldiers and civilians was initiated to form.

The government divided the country into 11 sectors. Besides, some sub-sectors and 3 Brigade forces were formed. The Bangalee officers served the Pakistan army, the police, EPR, members of the Navy and Air Force joined these sectors. There were soldiers, guerrillas and general fighters in every sector. They were usually called MuktiJoddha or Muktifouz (the freedom fighters). Students, youth, women, farmers ,political activists and supporters, labourers and various professionals joined these forces. After receiving training in different training camps, the warriors entered the country and attacked the Pakistan army camps, barracks and other military establishments. Several troops were spontaneously organised inside the country to take part in the Liberation War except the troops formed under the Mujibnagar Government. These troops played a significant role in the 3 war against the Pakistan army and the Razakars in local areas. The name of Kaderia Bahini (Cadre of Kader Siddiqui) of Tangail is still remembered by the people. Under the leadership of Mujibnagar Government ,the freedom fighters fought in the battle fields to liberate the country from the occupation of the Pakistani forces. Many of them sacrificed their lives for the cause of the mother land and many of them suffered casualties.

6 The Role of the General People and Professionals in the Liberation War

The students, general people, Police, EPR (East Pakistan Rifles) bravely resisted when the Pakistan army swooped on the unarmed people on 25 March 1971. The Bangalees did not give up resisting the enemy, and many freedom fighters sacrificed their lives in the battlefield and many others became permanently disabled with bullet wounds. The country is deeply indebted to these freedom fighters for their sacrifices. The nation will always remember them as the valiant sons of the soil. The freedom fighters risked their own lives and joined the war to liberate the country. They

were brave warriors and patriots inspired by the spirit of self-sacrifice, The Bangalees from all walks of life participated in the war. That is why this war was termed as Ganojudha or Janojudha (a battle of the mass people). The people were the major controlling force of this war of independence.

7 Women in the Liberation War

The role of women in the liberation war was glorious. The participation of women especially the female students was spontaneous in the Sangram Parishad (The Action Committee) constituted at the beginning of March 1971 in every part of the country. They took part directly in the war after having training in handling the firearms and in guerilla warfare in the training camps along with the male fighters. Besides, a large number of female freedom fighters as fellow soldiers, providing the freedom fighters with shelters, collecting information of the enemies and nursing the wounded fighters played a vital role in the war. Nearly 3 lakh women were molested by the Pakistani army. They were fellow fighters too, and as recognition of their sacrifice, Bangabandu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman gave them the title of honour Birangona (the heroic woman). The Awami League Government declared them as freedom fighters in 2016.

8 The Mass Media

The role of the media in the liberation war of Bangladesh was enormous. The newspapers and the Shawdhin Bangla Betar Kendra played a leading role in this regard. The artists and cultural activists of Chittagong Radio Station the Shawdin Bangla Betar Kendra on 26 March 1971. Later it ran under the supervision of the Mujibnagar government. The Shawdhin Bangla Betar Kendra broadcast news, patriotic songs, heroic deeds of freedom fighters, events of warfield and thus inspired the general people to join the liberation war. It encouraged the freedom fighters, and contributed a lot to win the war. Besides, the newspaper Joy Bangla circulated by the publication cell under the supervision of the Mujibnagar government also played important roles in the liberation war.

9 The Role of the Artists , Writers and Intellectuals

The key regulating factor of the liberation war was the people. However, the role of the artists, writers, intellectuals and cultural workers was very praiseworthy. Articles in the newspapers, news cast in the Shawdhin Bangla Betar Kendra, patriotic songs based on the liberation war, recitations of poetry, drama, talks, Charampatra and Jollader Dorbar, the most popular programmes, etc. contributed a lot to move the war ahead. All these helped to boost up the spirit of the freedom fighters, encouraged them, and made the general people indomitable against the enemy.

10 The Leadership of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman

The main leadership in the liberation war of Bangladesh came from Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman the architect of independence and father of the nation. He devoted all the activities, struggles and movements of his life to achieve freedom of the Bangalee nation. He put in a lot of effort to establish the Chatra League in 1948, and the Awami League in 1949. He played a vital role in the language movement in 1948 and 1952. He was the most prominent among the first detainees of the language movement. Irrespective of the assembly or of the street, he was always vocal in favour of Bangalee language and culture. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the father of the nation played the most important role single handedly in the Jukto (United) Front election in 1954, in the movement to get the constitutional recognition of Bangla as the state language in 1956, in organizing agitation against the martial law of General Ayub Khan in 1958, in the movement to realise the 6 Point Demands in 1966, in mass uprising of 1969, in the landslide victory of the Awami League in the election of 1970, from the non-cooperation movement to the declaration of Independence and in winning the liberation war in 1971. Bangabandhu had to spend in prison as a political detainee for long 12 years out of 24 years of the Pakistan regime. He gave the clarion call for freedom in his historic 7 March, 1971 speech in sequence of struggle. When the Pakistan army swooped on the innocent people of the country with utter cruelty on 25 March, he formally declared the independence of Bangladesh in the early hour of 26 March 1971. He called for the war of independence in his great oration of 7 March 1971 following the ways of armed struggle. Our liberation war was directed after his name. He was the Commander-in-Chief of the liberation war and the President of the Mujibnagar government. We achieved the

independence for his strong and uncompromising leadership. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman is the father of the nation, the great leader of our independence and the great architect of a sovereign Bangladesh.

11 The Opinion of the world Community and the Role of the foreign Countries during the Liberation War

The brutalities of the Pakistani occupation army to the people of Bangladesh during the liberation war in 1971 gave a jolt to the conscience of the world community. They woke up and protested against the booty, arson, molestation of women and mass killing by the Pakistani soldiers and their collaborators of this land. Many countries condemned and protested against the brutalities and expressed support to the liberation war. The world community raised their voice against the genocide in the night of blackout on 25 March nay the national Genocide Day and afterwards. The people around the world directly or indirectly supported the liberation war of Bangladesh.

The Role of India: Our neighbouring country India directly supported Bangladesh, and successfully highlighted the crimes of mass killing, atrocity, violence on women, booty committed by the Pakistani invading army since 25 March to the next nine months. So the consciences of world community received a jolt. India provided shelter, food, clothes, medicine to the millions of refugees, and arms and ammunition with necessary training to the freedom fighters. In the last stage of the war, Pakistan initiated airstrikes to India. India recognised Bangladesh on 6 December 1971. The Mukti Bahini (freedom fighters) and the Indian force jointly initiated the Joutha (Joint) Com-mand. A total of 93 thousand Pakistani army surrendered to the Joutha Command after an all out attack launched by them on the Pakistani army. A large number of Indian soldiers died in the liberation war .

The Soviet Union and the Role of the Socialist Countries: most to the liberation war of Bangladesh, next to that, the then Soviet Union (present Russia). The Soviet President called upon President General Yahia Khan of Pakistan to stop mass killing, booty, arson, and the violence on women. He also urged Yahia to hand over the power to the elected body. The Soviet newspapers, mass media highlighted the atrocities of the Pakistani army and the armed resistance of the freedom fighters in the war to drum up the support for the cause. When the USA tried to table a proposal at

the United Nations to declare a ceasefire in Pakistan's favour, the Soviet Union used its veto to block the proposal. The then socialist countries like Cuba, Yugoslavia, Poland, Hungary, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia, East Germany etc. supported the liberation war of Bangladesh. The Role of Great Britain: The British media, specially the BBC and newspapers published from London highlighted the genocide and the brutality of Pak-army, the resistance of the Bengalees, the plight of the refugees sheltered in India, and the development of liberation war to have support of the world community. The British government was also very sympathetic about our liberation war. It is worth-mentioning that London was the main campaigning centre for drumming up support for our war of liberation. Besides, the British born' singer George Harrison along with Ravi Shanker and Ali Akber Khan organized a concert in New York to have support of the world community and raise funds to help the distressed people of Bangladesh. About 40,000 people attended the concert where Harrison sang songs describing the anti-inhuman activities of the Pak-army in our liberation war. The media of Australia, West German, France, Italy, Japan and Canada along with Britain helped winning the support of the world community against the atrocities of the Pakistani invading army. Iraq also supported Bangladesh. The people, media, and some congressmen of the United States supported our liberation war, but it is a sad truth that some of the countries opposed the war of independence.

The Role of United Nations: The main objective of the United Nations is to establish world peace and maintain security throughout the world. When Pak-Junta Yahia Khan was jealously engaged in slaughtering the Bengalis instead of handing over the power to the elected body of East Pakistan, then the UN remained silent. It did not take any effective measure against the genocide and the violation of fundamental rights. In fact, the UN did not have any power to act on its own initiative except the five influential countries that could exercise the veto.

12 The Historic Significance of the Liberation War

The liberation war of Bangladesh is a significant event in the world history. Bangladesh was the first among the third world countries that achieved independence through armed struggle. The people of East Pakistan were the victims of oppression, repression and exploitation since 1947 by the Pakistani rulers, but the rebellious people of this land revolted against all the evils that came

to an end with the victory in the liberation war on 16 December 1971. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the greatest leader of the liberation war called for the independence on 7 March 1971 and formally declared it on 26 March, and after 'an armed struggle of nine months, we achieved it on 16 December 1971. The mass people of this country provided all cooperation to the freedom fighters. As a result, the liberation war became the expression of the Bengali nationalism. The liberation war created a new patriotic zeal among the Bengalis and different ethnic communities living in this land, and they being inspired by this zeal, engaged themselves in the reconstruction of a war torn country, we have got an independent country through the war of liberation, and she has secured her position in the world map. The dream that the Bengalis nourished for thousand years came true through the victory in the war. The liberation war of Bangladesh inspired the oppressed people of the world desirous of freedom.